Khrushchev's letter. Dean Rusk was speaking to the group, declaring the news a victory for everyone, irrespective of the position they had taken during the negotiations. "I think there is some gratification of everyone's line of action," Rusk told the gathering. Bundy, less than completely satisfied with Rusk's "feel good" speech, said that it was the "day of the doves." Undoubtedly it was Kennedy's day—a reluctant hawk at the start of the crisis, he had become a committed "dove."

Kennedy, who had turned on the tape recorder at first, turned it off after listening for a few minutes to his aides' self-congratulatory remarks. He was also dismissive of their compliments. One of them had suggested, while Kennedy was chatting with Ted Sorensen outside the Cabinet Room, that he was now in a position to do almost anything, including ending the ongoing war between China and India. As Kennedy denied that possibility, the aide told him: "But Mr. President, today you're more than ten feet tall." "That will last about a couple of weeks," responded Kennedy, laughing.[4]

The peacemaker in the White House had yet to explain his unexpected and stunning success to his generals and most of his aides. But his standing at home and in the international arena had just been transformed in a matter of hours, if not minutes. After having been accused of weakness by his predecessor, and then of losing one confrontation after another with Khrushchev, he had suddenly become a hero who was capable of standing his ground and forcing a powerful enemy to retreat. If up to that point he had been reacting to Khrushchev, who held the initiative, he would now consistently maintain the upper hand. Nevertheless, Kennedy's laurel wreath was full of thorns, since he had one more skeleton to hide in his closet—the Cuba-Turkey missile swap.

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THE EXCOM SESSION THAT FOLLOWED BECAME ONE OF THE shortest in the committee's history, lasting from 11:10 a.m. to 12:15 p.m. The participants canceled reconnaissance flights that day to avoid possible accidents and decided what UN inspection of the withdrawal of Soviet missiles would mean in practice. The United States would be prepared to monitor the